The entire area was teeming with troops. The priority now was to provide adequate habitat for these additional forces, particularly if we had to sustain through the winter. Plans for this were formulated and started getting implemented.

Prior to these developments, the second round of SHMCL talks had been held on 22 June, a week after the Galwan clash. The PLA tried to lay the blame for the clash on us, which was categorically rejected. In an unguarded moment, during a break in the talks, when the two Generals were by themselves, Maj Gen Liu Lin even mentioned having suffered numerous fatal casualties, including their CO (which was belatedly accepted by the Chinese) but did not specify any numbers. While the focus was on restarting the deliberations to finalize modalities for disengagement, the shadow of the clash loomed over the talks and not much headway was made. As part of the dialogue with China was another process called the WMCC—the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India–China Border Affairs. The WMCC had been set up through an India–China agreement in January 2012, for improved institutionalized information exchange on border-related issues.[7] The WMCC was to be headed by a Joint Secretary-level officer on either side. In our case, it was Shri Naveen Srivastava, then JS in the East Asia Division of the MEA.[8] Naveen was to play a crucial role in the talks that followed.

As part of the joint efforts and coordination between the MEA and Defence, it was decided that there should be a WMMC meeting before or after each round of Corps Commander-level talks, i.e., the SHMCL talks. This would enable us to project our point in a more formal and institutionalized manner with the added advantage that minutes of the WMCC meetings were on record, and thus less prone to misinterpretation or

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